

Virginia - 2026 Preseason Primer

2026 COLLEGE FOOTBALL PRESEASON PRIMER | ACC

Legend: trend - ● ↑ better · ● ↔ similar · ● ↓ worse · **assessment** - ● strong/positive · ● average/mixed/uncertain · ● weak/negative · ♦ new player or coach

1. 60-Second Briefing

Initial conclusions

Question	Answer
How good?	Above-average Power 4 / credible upper-half ACC team, with a defense and veteran offensive line capable of carrying a reworked skill-position offense.
Preseason consensus	AP others receiving votes (1 vote/point) · ACC media ACC No. 6 · SP+ No. 37
Returning production	61% (No. 31) overall · Off. 55% (No. 64) · Def. 67% (No. 9)
Primer power rating	+8.0 points vs. average FBS
Expected season	7.8 wins · likely 8-4
Net vs. 2025	● ↓ Worse than the 11-win peak but still solidly competitive; defensive continuity and OL experience offset major QB/WR/pass-rush replacement work.
Confidence	Medium-high

2026 identity: Virginia leans on a veteran OL, a deep RB committee and QB Beau Pribula while a rebuilt WR room develops. DC John Rudzinski keeps a rotation-heavy defense with a deep secondary; LB/edge health is the main constraint.

Bottom line: Virginia is more likely to regress from 11 wins than collapse: the defense and OL provide a sturdy floor, but a new quarterback, almost entirely rebuilt receiver production and uncertain edge health make another conference-title-level season a tougher ask.

Beats expectations if: QB Beau Pribula is efficient behind the veteran line, at least two transfer receivers emerge quickly, and LB Kam Robinson plus the edge rotation are healthy enough for the defense to preserve its 2025 down-to-down strength.

Disappoints if: The rebuilt passing game lacks explosive answers, the replacement pass rush cannot reproduce DL Daniel Rickert/DE Mitchell Melton pressure, and preseason injury questions linger into league play.

Five things to remember

- 1 Quarterback:** QB Beau Pribula entered camp as Virginia's No. 1 quarterback, but he inherits a receiver room replacing four of the five 2025 wideouts with at least 16 catches.
- 2 ★ Preseason recognition:** The projected offensive line is unusually settled: LT McKale Boley-LG Noah Josey-Metcalf-Thomas-Mills, with LT McKale Boley and LG Noah Josey carrying first-team ACC recognition.
- 3 2025 baseline:** Virginia's 2025 defense was genuinely strong across adjusted rating, success rate, explosives and havoc, not just in raw scoring defense.
- 4 Defensive front:** LB Kam Robinson is back in practice and moving through nearly everything, but remains a game-time decision as Virginia evaluates his return to contact; the edge rotation still carries its own health questions.
- 5 Schedule pressure:** The schedule is middle-of-the-pack by SP+ (SOS No. 67), creating a realistic path to eight-plus wins if the new passing game stabilizes.

2. 2025 in Context

Traditional Stats

Measure	2025	Assessment
Record	11-3 (7-3 ACC)	● Excellent
Scoring	30.8 PPG	● Good / above average
Total offense	417.9 YPG	● Very good
Rush offense	178.7 YPG · 4.6 YPC	● Good / above average
Pass efficiency	6.80 YPA · 18 TD / 10 INT	● Average / mixed
Third downs	49.8%	● Elite
Scoring defense	19.6 PPG allowed	● Very good
Total defense	309.5 YPG allowed	● Very good
Rush defense	113.9 YPG · 3.4 YPC	● Very good
Pass defense	195.6 YPG · 6.65 YPA · 15 TD allowed	● Very good

Virginia paired a top-30 offense and elite third-down rate with a strong defense; offensive pass efficiency was the notable weakness.

Advanced Stats

Measure	2025	Assessment
Opp.-adjusted offense	+1.96 · No. 53	● Average / mixed
Off. EPA/play	+0.047 · No. 48	● Good / above average
Off. success rate	42.9% · No. 65	● Average / mixed
Off. explosive-play rate	11.6% · No. 86	● Below average
Havoc allowed	13.0% · No. 30	● Very good
Opp.-adjusted defense	+4.56 · No. 25	● Very good
Def. EPA/play allowed	-0.098 · No. 29	● Very good
Def. success rate allowed	37.0% · No. 21	● Very good
Def. explosive-play rate allowed	10.0% · No. 28	● Very good
Havoc created	17.9% · No. 22	● Very good

Advanced-stat read: Virginia’s 2025 record was supported by a defense with no obvious play-level weakness: adjusted defense No.25, EPA/play allowed No.29, success rate allowed No.21, explosive prevention No.28 and havoc created No.22.

EPA and success rate use CFB Graphs regular-season data. Explosive rate uses regular-season non-garbage-time cfbfastR plays; explosive = 10+ yd rush or 20+ yd pass. Havoc = TFL + forced fumbles + passes defended per play. Lower is better for defensive rates and offensive havoc allowed.

3. Coaching

Role	2026 status	Quick impact
HC	Tony Elliott - returning same role	● ↔ Tony Elliott's return keeps the program structure stable.
OC / play-caller	Des Kitchings - returning OC/TE; offensive play-calling continuity is established	● ↔ Des Kitchings returns with established offensive play-calling continuity.
DC / scheme owner	John Rudzinski - returning DC; exact game-day defensive caller remains unresolved	● ↔ Coordinator role is clear; primary game-day caller remains unresolved

4. Key Roster Movement

Offense

In	From	Expected effect
◆ QB Beau Pribula	Missouri	● ↔ Current QB1 and a credible bridge after QB Chandler Morris, but not enough for a clean upgrade.
◆ RB Jekail Middlebrook / Peyton Lewis / Solomon Beebe	Middle Tennessee / Tennessee / UAB	● ↔ Deepens the committee replacing RB J'Mari Taylor.
◆ WR Rico Flores Jr. / Jacquon Gibson / Da'Shawn Martin / Tyson Davis	UCLA / UMass / Kent State / Central Michigan	● ↔ Rebuilds a room with only one returning 16-catch WR.

Out	To	Loss
QB Chandler Morris	Final eligibility / graduation	● ↓ 2025 starting quarterback departs after the 11-win season.
WR Trell Harris	Oklahoma	● ↓ Team-leading 59-catch receiver leaves, creating the largest single receiving-production hole.
RB J'Mari Taylor	NFL (Jacksonville), undrafted free agent	● ↓ 1,062-yard, 14-touchdown lead back departs via confirmed UDFA path.

Offensive net: modest downgrade in certainty and proven production

Defense

In	From	Expected effect
◆ EDGE Matthew Fobbs-White / Nnanna Anyanwu / Ezekiel Larry	Baylor / UTSA / Yale	● ↔ Replaces pass-rush losses, with preseason availability caveats.
◆ S Brandyn Hillman	Michigan	● ↑ Experienced all-conference-level addition who raises the secondary's ceiling even with final alignment unsettled.

Out	To	Loss
DL Daniel Rickert	Final eligibility / graduation	● ↓ Led Virginia with 6.5 sacks in 2025.
DE Mitchell Melton	NFL (Indianapolis), undrafted free agent	● ↓ Five-sack edge contributor departs via confirmed UDFA path.
S Devin Neal	NFL (Jacksonville), undrafted free agent	● ↓ Fourteen-game starter and 88-tackle safety departs.

Defensive net: roughly stable at a high level, but with more pass-rush and health uncertainty

5. How They Play

Phase	Identity	What works	Main vulnerability
Offense	Veteran-line offense built to give QB Beau Pribula manageable structure, use a deep RB committee and move TE John Rogers around the formation while the receiver hierarchy develops.	Three returning OL starters plus a settled projected five; a six-back scholarship room offers depth and role flexibility.	Explosive passing: the 2025 explosive rate was only No.86 and most established receiver production is gone.
Defense	Rotation-heavy DC John Rudzinski unit with varied pressure and a deep back seven.	Strong 2025 adjusted rating, success-rate defense, explosive prevention and havoc.	Replacing 11.5 sacks while LB Kam Robinson and multiple edges work through health questions.
Special teams	Established specialist core with recognition at both kicker and punter.	Bettridge is on the Groza list and P Daniel Sparks is ACC first team/Ray Guy watch.	SP+ special-teams No.58 suggests the full unit should not be treated as elite solely from specialist recognition.

6. Unit Grades

Unit	Grade	vs. 2025	Confidence	Why
QB	● B–	● ↓	Medium-high	Entered camp as QB1 and determines whether Virginia can convert line/RB stability into enough passing efficiency.
RB	● B	● ↔	Medium	Earned the first turn in a deep six-back room and is the clearest initial replacement for lost lead-back production.
WR	● C+	● ↓	Medium-low	Only returning Virginia WR with at least 16 catches in 2025; continuity anchor for a transfer-heavy room.
TE	● B–	● ↔	Medium	TE John Rogers supplies a defined role in a reworked passing game.
OL	● B+	● ↔	High	Anchors the veteran projected five and is one of the clearest reasons to trust the offensive floor.
DL/Edge	● B–	● ↓	Medium-low	His 4.5 sacks lead Virginia’s returners after DL Daniel Rickert and DE Mitchell Melton departed.
LB	● B+	● ↔	Medium	The defense’s most recognized player and a central returning piece; Kam Robinson is practicing again but remains a game-time decision.
Secondary	● B+	● ↔	Medium	A deep returning group adds experienced S Brandyn Hillman.
Special teams	● B+	● ↔	Medium-high	P Daniel Sparks and K Will Bettridge provide established specialists.
Coaching	● B+	● ↔	High	Staff continuity is strong; the defensive game-day caller remains unresolved.
Overall	● B	● ↓	Medium-high	Above-average Power 4 / credible upper-half ACC team, with a defense and veteran offensive line capable of carrying a reworked skill-position offense.

7. Players to Know

Recognition status: official conference honors and major award watchlists through August 24, 2026.

Player	Pos.	Evaluation	Preseason recognition	Why he matters
Kam Robinson	LB	● High-end ACC linebacker / availability monitor	ACC Preseason Team: first team · Bednarik Award · Butkus Award	Back in practice and ahead of schedule, but still a game-time decision as contact work is evaluated.
McKale Boley	LT	● High-end conference tackle	ACC Preseason Team: first team	Anchors the veteran projected five and is one of the clearest reasons to trust the offensive floor.
Noah Josey	LG	● High-end conference guard	ACC Preseason Team: first team · Outland Trophy	Second recognized OL anchor in a line that should be the offense’s most stable unit.
Beau Pribula	QB	● Solid Power 4 starter projection	-	Entered camp as QB1 and determines whether Virginia can convert line/RB stability into enough passing efficiency.
Jekail Middlebrook	RB	● Lead-committee back projection	-	Earned the first turn in a deep six-back room and is the clearest initial replacement for lost lead-back production.
Kameron Courtney	WR	● Key returning receiver	-	Only returning Virginia WR with at least 16 catches in 2025; continuity anchor for a transfer-heavy room.
Fisher Camac	DE	● Returning edge anchor	-	His 4.5 sacks lead Virginia’s returners after Rickert and Melton departed.
Daniel Sparks	P	● High-end conference punter	ACC Preseason Team: first team · Ray Guy Award	Established punter and one of four forced-recognition players in the layer.

8. Schedule

Item	Assessment
Overall	● A favorable enough slate for Virginia to stay in the ACC’s upper half, with few elite opponents but a concentrated October road/league grind.
Difficulty	● 5/10 · SP+ SOS No. 67
Hardest stretch	at Florida State → Syracuse → at SMU → Duke → at Wake Forest (Oct. 3-31)
Swing games	NC State, at Florida State, at Wake Forest, at Virginia Tech
Advantage	Two September home games against Norfolk State and Delaware plus a Nov. 7 bye before the final three-game run.
Expected	7.8 wins · likely 8-4
Floor / ceiling	6-6 / 10-2

9. Betting Lens

Angle	Read
Market posture	Virginia’s 11-win 2025 can create an inflated brand/record anchor, but the 2026 roster still has a credible defensive/OL floor; price them closer to a solid top-40 team than to last year’s win total.
Back them when	Prefer Virginia when the matchup rewards OL/defensive consistency and does not require repeated explosive passing, especially against teams vulnerable to pressure or sustained rushing efficiency.
Fade/pass when	Fade or pass when the price assumes last season’s win rate will repeat, or against opponents that can protect the passer and force the rebuilt Virginia receiver/edge groups to win one-on-one.
Key monitor	Kam Robinson game-time availability and edge health, WR hierarchy/explosiveness, replacement pass rush
Week 1 baseline	Virginia -4.5 vs. NC State · rating-only baseline; Virginia primer +8.0 minus NC State primer +5.5 plus 2.0 default home field; no matchup or availability adjustment. Compare with the live market before betting. Live market: Virginia -5.5 (CBS Sports, Aug. 25).

10. Summary

Virginia’s floor is unusually sturdy for a team replacing its starting QB and most of its receiver production. A veteran OL, deep RB room and strong returning defense give QB Beau Pribula room to manage the transition, provided the new WR group creates enough explosiveness.

The defense should remain the team’s strength, though pass-rush replacement and LB/edge health matter. With a moderate schedule, **7.8 wins and 8-4** is a reasonable baseline - solid upper-half ACC quality, but below the 11-win peak.

About this primer

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Sources: [2026 roster](#) · [camp overview](#) · [defense preview](#) · [WR preview](#) · [TE preview](#) · [OL preview](#) · [OC Kitchings](#) · [OL dismissal](#) · [Robinson availability update](#)

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